FREE GUIDE · RALEIGH · DURHAM · THE TRIANGLE

10 Before you buy

10 costly mistakes Triangle home buyers make, and how to avoid them



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BEFORE YOU BUY

Buying in Raleigh, Durham and the Triangle moves fast, and North Carolina does a few things differently from other states. These are the mistakes I see cost buyers the most money, stress and time, with what to do instead.

01 Shopping before you are pre-approved

Sellers here expect a pre-approval letter with your offer. Without one, you can fall in love with a home and lose it to a buyer who was ready. Get pre-approved first so you also know your real budget.

02 Talking to only one lender

Rates, fees and programs vary from lender to lender. Ask two or three for a Loan Estimate, the standard three-page form, and compare them line by line.

03 Missing help for first-time buyers

The NC Housing Finance Agency offers the NC Home Advantage Mortgage with down payment assistance for eligible buyers, and some Triangle cities run their own programs. Ask your lender which ones you qualify for.

04 Forgetting the cash you need besides the down payment

In North Carolina you usually pay a due diligence fee and an earnest money deposit soon after your offer is accepted, then closing costs, the inspection and the appraisal. Budget for all of it from the start.

05 Not understanding the due diligence period

The standard North Carolina offer gives you a due diligence period to inspect, appraise and finalize your loan. You can walk away during it for any reason, but the due diligence fee is generally not refundable. Use every day of it.

06 Skipping or rushing the inspection

A home can look perfect and still hide roof, plumbing or moisture problems. Inspect during due diligence, read the full report, and decide what to ask the seller to repair.

07 Looking at the price instead of the monthly payment

Property taxes change by county and city, and insurance, HOA dues and mortgage insurance all add up. Compare homes by their full monthly cost, not just the list price.

08 Ignoring the HOA rules

Many Triangle neighborhoods have an HOA. Read the rules and fees before you commit: rental limits, fences, parking, paint colors and special assessments can all affect you.

09 Changing your finances before closing

A new car, a new credit card, a job change or large unexplained deposits can delay or even stop your loan. Keep everything steady until you have the keys.

10 Going it alone, or not reading your buyer agreement

Since August 2024, buyers sign a written agreement with their agent before touring homes. Read it, ask how your agent is paid, and remember the terms are negotiable. A good agent explains every line.

You do not have to figure this out alone.

I walk families through every one of these steps, in English or Spanish. Tell me about your plans and I will prepare options before we even meet.

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